DEATH OF AN EMPEROR

In 1605, the Mughal court at Agra found itself with an excess of pretenders to one of the richest empires in history. The Mughal Empire was now greater in size than any previous Indian kingdom bar the Mauryan Empire of nearly two millennia previously, far larger than any contemporary European kingdom, and was rivalled only by China. It included much of modern-day Afghanistan, Pakistan, and Bangladesh, including the cities of Kandahar, Kabul, and Dhaka. It contained Kashmir and southern Kumaon, and stretched upto Bengal, along the line of the Himalayas. In the Deccan, Khandesh and Ahmadnagar were part of the empire and Berar was about to be incorporated too. Up to a million people lived within it. A hundred metric tons of silver flowed every year into the empire, brought in by Europeans buying manufactured goods and natural resources from Hindustan, which accounted for about a quarter of all global manufacturing. The Mughal emperor, with an annual income estimated at 100 million pounds[*] was by far the richest ruler in the world. An army of 300,000 men defended the empire's frontiers while an additional four million infantry could be mobilized when required. This glittering empire, moreover, had been carefully reconfigured as an indivisible entity, to be inherited by a single, chosen heir. No longer would brothers be equal co-rulers, with lands of their own. This was now an empire worth fighting and dying for.

With Daniyal dying in March 1605, Akbar had only one living son remaining but, importantly, he had two grandsons. Akbar had always favoured Salim's younger son, Khurram, finding in him an heir true to his own talents and ambition. In this the Padshah showed himself an excellent judge of character, as Khurram would go on to become Shah Jahan, most magnificent of all the Mughals of Hindustan. But in 1605, it was eighteen-year-old Khusrau who was a legitimate contender for the throne, an alternative for those who had serious doubts about the temperamental, cruel, and volatile Salim.

With his own father still living, Khusrau's pretensions to rule should never have been a possibility at all. Tall and elegant like his father, but with his Rajput mother's large eyes and pleasantly regular features, Khusrau's